STEP 7

Risks, Trade-offs and Constraints

Fireflies.ai Product Management Launchpad Capstone

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Decision focus: improve honest commitment closure without creating false completion, unwanted ownership, notification overload, or a manager-surveillance experience.

1. Executive Summary

The proposed product direction combines (1) owner-confirmed commitment handoff and (2) lightweight, explicit resolution controls inside Fireflies Tasks. These concepts address the continuity gap between a commitment discussed in a meeting and a verifiable outcome. They remain product hypotheses: the available interviews provide directional examples of follow-up, handoffs, dependencies, and fragmented tracking, but do not establish one universal root cause or prove that the proposed experience will achieve the case-study target.

The main product risk is optimizing the metric instead of the underlying behavior. A commitment should count as resolved only when it is explicitly marked Done, deliberately dropped, or reassigned and accepted by the new owner. Silence, an unaccepted reassignment, a blocked state, or an unconfirmed suggested owner must not be treated as closure.

What the recommendation means in practice

The product should make two things easier: first, confirming who has agreed to own a commitment; second, recording the commitment's real outcome. It should not pressure people to close work just to improve a dashboard.

Example: a meeting produces the action "send the revised proposal by Friday." The suggested owner confirms or clarifies responsibility. If the proposal is sent, the commitment is marked Done. If the team decides it is no longer needed, it is marked Deliberately dropped. If another person takes over, the commitment is resolved only after that person accepts. If the owner is waiting on customer data, it remains Blocked/Waiting; if nobody updates it, it remains unresolved.

The business goal is to increase the share of eligible commitments that reach one of these honest, explicit outcomes within 14 days—from the case-study baseline of 28% toward the target of 45% over six months. The target is not a forecast. A pilot must test whether the experience improves closure without increasing false completion, unwanted assignment, notification fatigue, or loss of trust.

In short: measure whether commitments reach an honest outcome, not whether users click more status buttons.

Decision principle	Implication for the product
Trust before automation	Suggest owners only when there is a defensible signal; require confirmation and allow decline or clarification.
Honest closure over vanity metrics	Keep Done, Deliberately dropped, and Accepted reassignment distinct in analytics and user-facing history.
Low-friction adoption	Reuse existing Fireflies Tasks and meeting context; avoid building a second project-management system.
Autonomy over surveillance	Give individuals control over their commitments and avoid ranking people by overdue or dropped items.
Evidence before scale	Pilot with event instrumentation, guardrails, and a comparison design before claiming impact.

2. Product Direction and Boundaries

The risk analysis assumes the two-solution direction from Step 3 and the MVP scope from Step 4.

In scope for the initial experience

- A commitment record linked to its source meeting and relevant context.
- Owner confirmation, clarification, or decline before a suggested owner becomes the accepted owner.
- Explicit status actions for Done, Deliberately dropped, and reassignment; reassignment is not resolved until the new owner accepts.
- Non-terminal states such as Needs owner confirmation, In progress, and Blocked/Waiting.
- Minimal, contextual reminders and a clear activity history.
- Optional manual task creation and supporting links or attachment metadata as a supporting workflow—not a third core solution.

Out of scope

- Transcription infrastructure or commitment-extraction model development.
- Security architecture redesign or pricing redesign.
- Replacing Jira, CRM, Smartsheet, or other task-management systems.
- A comprehensive manager surveillance dashboard or employee performance ranking.
- Assuming that links or attachment metadata in a prototype mean files are uploaded, parsed, or durably stored.

3. Risk Register

Risk	Severity	Failure mode	Mitigation / design response	Monitoring signal
R1 — False or coerced ownership	High	A person is assigned a commitment they did not accept; this undermines trust and may create inaccurate accountability.	Require explicit acceptance; support decline/clarify; preserve who proposed and who accepted; do not infer consent from meeting attendance.	Owner acceptance rate; decline/clarification rate; unconfirmed-owner share; qualitative trust feedback.
R2 — Metric gaming / false closure	High	Users mark Done or drop work to improve the resolution rate even when the underlying outcome is not honestly represented.	Separate Done, Deliberately dropped, and Accepted reassignment; capture optional drop reason; retain status history; audit reversals and rapid reopenings.	Resolution-type mix; reopen/correction rate; short-cycle Done/drop patterns; sample-based quality review.
R3 — Reassignment counted too early	High	A reassignment request is counted as resolved before the new owner accepts, overstating closure.	Treat reassignment as pending until accepted; record request and acceptance as separate events; only acceptance qualifies for the case-study definition.	Pending reassignment share; request-to-accept time; event-to-UI reconciliation.
R4 — Notification fatigue	High	Repeated reminders increase annoyance, muting, and disengagement.	Start with restrained, contextual reminders; use user preferences and deduplication; avoid repeated notifications for blocked items without a meaningful change.	Notifications per commitment; mute/disable rate; opt-out rate; complaint feedback; return-use rate.
R5 — Surveillance perception	High	Team-level views or manager notifications make the product feel like employee monitoring rather than coordination support.	Default to personal/action-oriented views; show shared status only where useful; avoid leaderboards, individual rankings, and punitive language.	Trust feedback; view-access patterns; adoption by ICs; qualitative concerns raised during pilot.
R6 — Integration and workflow fragmentation	Medium–High	A new workflow creates duplicate task records or forces teams to leave their current systems.	Keep Fireflies as a lightweight commitment layer; support links to existing work systems first; defer deep two-way sync until demand and feasibility are validated.	Link-out usage; duplicate-task reports; manual re-entry burden; task abandonment.
R7 — Ambiguous commitment semantics	High	Vague meeting language or missing criteria leads to tasks that cannot be completed or judged fairly.	Allow owner clarification of action, due date, and completion criteria; avoid mandatory fields unless evidence shows they are necessary.	Clarification rate; edits after creation; incomplete-record share; qualitative comprehension.
R8 — Dependencies mistaken for owner failure	High	A task remains blocked because data, approvals, or another team is late, but the record implies the owner failed.	Make Blocked/Waiting non-terminal; allow a concise dependency note and next expected checkpoint; avoid blame-oriented labels.	Blocked share and duration; dependency resolution time; owner trust feedback.
R9 — Adoption friction	Medium–High	Additional confirmation and status work feels like administrative overhead and users ignore the feature.	Use low-effort inline actions; prefill only supportable context; test activation and repeat use by role; avoid requiring every field for every task.	Time to first meaningful action; task creation completion; repeat use; abandonment.
R10 — Extraction or context errors	Medium–High	A misread action, owner, or deadline produces misleading commitment records.	Keep the existing extraction capability as a dependency, not a redesign target; let users edit/correct records	Correction rate; owner/action edits; deletion rate; false-positive reports.

			and distinguish suggested from confirmed fields.	
R11 — Privacy or over-collection	Medium–High	Tracking event payloads or task attachments capture more sensitive information than needed.	Use data minimization; avoid storing document contents in analytics; apply existing access controls; validate privacy requirements before launch.	Payload audit; access review; incident/complaint tracking; retention compliance.
R12 — Misleading business-impact claims	High	A higher resolution rate is presented as proof that more work was completed or customer value increased.	Report resolution types separately; compare treatment with a credible baseline; label hypotheses and limitations; track downstream outcomes where available.	14-day resolution rate; resolution mix; downstream completion/quality proxy; experiment confidence.

4. Key Trade-offs and Recommended Decisions

Trade-off	Tension	Recommended decision
Explicit owner confirmation vs. frictionless auto-assignment	Confirmation adds a step and may slow activation; auto-assignment can falsely imply agreement.	Prefer confirmation for the MVP. Measure time to owner decision and the share of commitments left unconfirmed. Consider lighter flows only after trust and accuracy are demonstrated.
Fast closure vs. honest closure	Broadly counting any status change as resolved would make the metric easier to improve but would misrepresent outcomes.	Keep the resolution definition strict: Done, Deliberately dropped, or reassigned with acceptance. Blocked and pending states remain unresolved.
More reminders vs. user control	More prompts may raise short-term status updates but can increase notification fatigue.	Start with a restrained cadence, contextual triggers, deduplication, and clear controls. Test frequency rather than assuming more reminders are better.
Manager visibility vs. individual autonomy	Shared visibility can help coordination but may feel like surveillance if designed around individual performance.	Prioritize action-oriented personal views and shared project context. Defer employee rankings and punitive escalation.
Deep integrations vs. delivery speed	Two-way integrations can reduce duplication but introduce scope, reliability, and maintenance costs.	Begin with meeting context and links to existing tools. Validate repeated user demand before building synchronization.
Required metadata vs. low effort	Mandatory due dates and completion criteria can improve clarity but may cause abandonment when the meeting did not establish them.	Make fields editable and conditionally prompted. Ask users to clarify only when needed; do not fabricate a deadline or completion criterion.
Single headline metric vs. nuanced outcomes	One North Star is easy to communicate but can conceal whether work was completed, dropped, or transferred.	Use the 14-day Commitment Resolution Rate as the North Star and always pair it with resolution-type mix, guardrails, and downstream indicators.

5. Measurement and Launch Guardrails

The case-study target is 45% of eligible commitments resolved within 14 days, against a stated baseline of 28%, within six months. This is a target, not a forecast. A pilot should establish whether the proposed experience changes behavior and whether any change is achieved without damaging trust or data quality.

North Star definition

14-Day Commitment Resolution Rate = eligible commitments reaching a qualifying resolution within 14 days ÷ all eligible commitments in the cohort × 100.

- Qualifying resolutions: explicitly Done, Deliberately dropped, or reassigned with acceptance by the new owner.
- Non-resolutions: silent inaction, Needs owner confirmation, pending reassignment, In progress, and Blocked/Waiting.
- Keep the resolution types visible in reporting so a higher rate caused mainly by dropping or reassignment is not misrepresented as more completed work.
- Finalize the cohort start event and the exact 14-day convention before launch; the current proposal uses the timestamp when the commitment first becomes a trackable record.

- Use mature cohorts only and compare treatment with a contemporaneous control or a pre-specified alternative when randomization is not feasible.

Guardrails to review alongside the North Star

Guardrail	Why it matters	Review signal
Ownership consent	A faster handoff is not valuable if it assigns work without agreement.	Acceptance, decline, clarification, and unconfirmed-owner rates.
Resolution integrity	Status changes must represent honest outcomes.	Done/drop/reassignment mix; correction and reopen rate.
Notification burden	Repeated prompts can erode adoption and trust.	Notifications per commitment; mute/disable and complaint rates.
User autonomy and trust	The experience should support coordination, not surveillance.	Role-based adoption and qualitative pilot feedback.
Workflow friction	Extra steps can lead to abandonment or duplicate work.	Creation/confirmation completion, time to action, and abandonment.
Equity across roles	A metric may perform differently across ICs, managers, admins, and buyers.	Segment outcomes by role/team where sample size and privacy permit.

6. Launch Readiness Checklist

Decision sequence for one commitment

1. Create or extract the commitment and retain its meeting context.
2. Ask the suggested owner to accept, decline, or clarify; do not assume agreement.
3. Track work as In progress or Blocked/Waiting while it remains open.
4. Close only as Done, Deliberately dropped, or Reassigned after the new owner accepts.
5. Measure the 14-day outcome and inspect the resolution type and guardrails before deciding to scale.

- Status definitions and resolution rules are reflected consistently in the UI, event schema, and reporting.
- A reassignment request does not count until the new owner accepts.
- Users can decline or clarify an ownership suggestion without being treated as non-compliant.
- Blocked/Waiting remains non-terminal and does not imply owner failure.
- Reminder frequency, deduplication, and user controls are tested before broad rollout.
- Event instrumentation preserves status history, uses stable commitment identifiers, and avoids duplicate event counting.
- Analytics separates extracted commitments from manually created tasks during initial evaluation.
- Privacy review covers task context, linked documents, attachment metadata, and event payloads.
- Pilot cohorts have a fixed observation window, a credible comparison plan, and a pre-agreed decision rule.
- The team has a process for reviewing correction/reopen patterns and user-reported false closure.

7. Decision Log

Decision	Rationale	Unresolved risk / validation needed
Require owner acceptance before ownership is treated as confirmed.	Protects consent and avoids assigning commitments to people who did not agree.	May increase time to confirmed ownership; test by role and commitment type.
Count accepted reassignment as resolved, but track it separately from Done.	Matches the case-study definition while preserving outcome nuance.	Stakeholders may misread the headline rate unless the mix is reported alongside it.
Treat Blocked/Waiting as non-terminal.	Distinguishes dependency delays from honest closure and avoids false completion.	Define when a blocked item should be revisited without creating reminder overload.
Use limited reminders and avoid individual rankings.	Reduces surveillance perception and notification fatigue.	The minimum effective reminder cadence is unknown and needs experimentation.
Defer deep two-way integrations.	Keeps MVP focused and avoids duplicating task-management platforms.	Links may be insufficient for teams that require synchronized status; validate in pilot.
Treat manual task creation as a supporting capability.	Allows users to capture missed or non-extracted commitments without making it the primary product bet.	Measure whether manual creation is used and whether those records behave differently.

8. Recommendation

Proceed with a controlled pilot of two connected capabilities: (1) owner confirmation, so a person can accept, decline, or clarify a proposed commitment; and (2) explicit resolution controls, so the record reflects whether the work was completed, deliberately dropped, or transferred to a new owner who has accepted it. Keep blocked work and silent inaction unresolved. Before expanding the pilot, verify that the UI, event tracking, and reporting use these definitions consistently; complete the privacy review; and review the results against a comparison group or another pre-specified evaluation plan.

The decision to scale should depend on whether users reach more honest, verifiable outcomes within 14 days with acceptable effort—and without unwanted ownership, misleading closure, notification overload, or a surveillance-like experience. Report Done, Deliberately dropped, and Accepted reassignment separately so the headline rate cannot hide what kind of resolution occurred.